

REUTERS/STEVE HOLLAND



LAST LAUGH: Team India after CB series win; (left) Dhoni with Sachin

world cricket. The opposition was relentless, the air was often blue but the Indians found it in them to remain competitive—and entertaining. No matter how much they were pushed, they didn't topple over. They have returned with credit and some silverware. India now owns Australia's home ODI trophy for perpetuity. After 29 years, the Aussies have done away with their annual ODI tri-series, viewed by most tourists as little else other than a trans-Australia trek punctuated by ritual poundings.

This year, a well-drilled swarm of buzzing bluebottles, led by Mahendra Singh Dhoni succeeded in throwing the Aussies off their game. Over a month and 10 matches, India went up against the two world cup finalists and were the best of the three teams. They regularly posted totals in excess of 240, and had Australia in trouble in almost every match. Hamstrung by injuries to

The CB series win is merely a BASE CAMP, from where India can aspire to grow to be a team of dominators.

Zaheer Khan and R.P. Singh, India had to test their bench and found Ishant Sharma and Praveen Kumar, men for different seasons provided they are handled well and stay fit. Srinath is delighted, "This bowling attack, the whole group, the choices we have, its the best we've seen put together in 25 years." Of the younger batsmen, only Gautam Gambhir made a significant stride forward but Rohit Sharma settled into the Indian line-up like he was always meant to be there.

"We shouldn't go overboard, but we're moving forward," says Sandeep Patil, former India coach. India are in a prime position in both forms of the game: in the afterflow of the ODIs, it is easy to forget that the Indians fought back from two Test defeats, to alter the momentum of the entire tour.

Of all the teams in world cricket who work with a split captaincy, India was never expected to succeed. Instead both Test captain Anil Kumble and Dhoni have made it appear like a natural state of affairs. In the CB series, Dhoni was

watched the game from Hamilton, New Zealand. He, too, knows that triumphal claims of India's world supremacy are premature and delusional. That would need a streak of victories around the globe. Not just for a series or two, but for seasons at a stretch. India's assignments this year (see box) will be a good test not just of its stamina, but also its discipline and sense of a mission.

In Australia, the Indians internalised some of those qualities for a little while, because they were able to keep going on in the toughest tour in

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MAY-JUNE	VS ZIMBABWE (AWAY)
JUNE	ASIA CUP (PAKISTAN)
JULY-AUGUST	VS SRI LANKA, 3 TESTS/5 ODIS
SEPTEMBER	ICC CHAMPIONS TROPHY
OCTOBER	VS AUSTRALIA, 4 TESTS
NOVEMBER	VS ENGLAND, 3 TESTS/7 ODIS
DECEMBER	VS PAKISTAN, 3 TESTS/5 ODIS